TOP DEMAND

- **After the LG regime hiked quotas for STs and OBCs in March, reservation in J&K went up to 60 per cent**
- **With high unemployment in the UT, job seekers from the general category want its roll-back**
- **CM Omar Abdullah has set up a panel of three ministers to revisit the reservation policy**

cent quota for STs. It also approved a 4 per cent increase in reservation for OBCs along with the addition of 15 new castes under the category, and so raised the OBC quota to 8 per cent. The 14 per cent increase in reservation took the overall quota to 60 per cent, leaving only 40 per cent of jobs for the 'general category'. This, the demand goes, is woefully inadequate for the majority of J&K's population.

"If the government fails, we'll move court against the unfair reservation. It should be on pro rata basis...the share of population should determine the proportion of reservation," Waheed ur Rehman Parra, a Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) legislator from Pulwama, said in an X Spaces audio conversation joined by hundreds of job aspirants.

However, changing the rules on reservation won't be easy. The Centre's 'Transaction of Business Rules' for the Union Territory of J&K vests control over security, public order, prosecution and appointments of top bureaucrats with the L-G, but there is confusion about the sharing of some responsibilities, including on reservation.

The present quotas also bump against another conundrum. The Supreme Court, in its landmark 1992 Indra Sawhney verdict, has capped reservation at 50 per cent. States like Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra Madhya Pradesh among others have breached the threshold, but such a breach is open to judicial review.

An official in the Jammu and Kashmir Service Selection Board (JKSSB) says recruitment will follow the amended quota of 60 per cent, which includes 10 per cent allocated to economically weaker backgrounds.

In India, J&K has the highest unemployment rate of 32 per cent in the 15-29 age group, according to the National Statistics Office's Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) for July-September. For females, the survey noted, unemployment stands at a staggering 53.6 per cent. The grim scenario is partly driven by the region's over-dependence on the government sector for employment. The private sector offers scant opportunities, with no major industries and lack of investment.

Farming, horticulture and agriculture contribute over 60 per cent of J&K's GDP, apart from the other mainstay—tourism. In his second stint as CM, Omar is trying to bolster employment generation in farmlands. "The fact is that we can't provide government jobs to everyone. This won't end unemployment in J&K. We'll have to look at our base, be it agriculture, handicrafts and floriculture," he has said. Kashmir's youth, of course, would prefer a regular job. ■

GIR, GUJARAT

WHERE HUMANS WANT A LION'S SHARE

By Jumana Shah

The Gir landscape in Saurashtra, Gujarat, has turned into a textbook case about the struggles of wildlife management in India. In mid-September, the Union government released a draft notification for an eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) around the Gir Wildlife Sanctuary (GWS). Earlier, a 0-10 km periphery around 1,468.16 sq km of the core territory of the GWS was considered a buffer zone which forbade the establishment of heavy, polluting industries and mining. In the revised draft, this area has shrunk substantially—to a minimum of 2.78 km from the sanctuary at some places and up to a maximum of 9.5 km at others. The draft proposes a 2,061 sq km region around Gir as an ESZ spread over 196 villages in Junagadh, Amreli and Gir Somnath districts, including 17 rivers, 24,000 hectares of forest area and 1.59 lakh hectares of non-forest area. The government statement says the protected area covers four important movement corridors of Asiatic lions in their sole habitat. A local naturalist estimates that the ESZ has approximately 38 per cent less area than the earlier buffer zone. However, even this is too much for thousands of local villagers, who fear loss of livelihood and development due to the strictures that will be implemented in an ESZ. The right to protect themselves from wild animals is also an issue.

In October 2015, the Union government had issued a notification earmarking 3,328 sq km around GWS covering 291 villages as ESZ, which extended up to 17.9 km at some points from the sanctuary perimeter. This drew widespread protests from locals